

Case Study: Online Food Delivery

Class: PhD Students of Commerce & Management (2026 June Cohort)

Discussion Date: 23/08/2026

Topic: Consumer Experiences and Behavior Towards Online Food Delivery Services

The objective of the case study is to establish a qualitative coding framework derived from an in-depth interview that was conducted during the class on 23rd August 2026. Based on the codes generated by this exercise, the central theme needs to be derived, which shall lay the foundation for understanding how the qualitative research needs to be further analyzed, based on the output of surveys/interviews or the methods used for analysis.

Team Details

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Interview Participants

Participant 1[P1]: Corporate professional residing in Whitefield, a dual-income family with two kids, food choice is diverse. Substantial weekly food order, with 2-4 times per week, preferred morning breakfast in certain scenario, when it too much effort to cook at home, also maintains a very close eye on food pricing, offers, discounts across distributed food ordering platforms.	Participant 2[P2]: Faculty at Manipal Academy, primary household meal planner and vegetarian as food choice. Very selective when it comes to ordering food online, as she prepares meals at home, however online orders are driven by post work exhaustion or son's request for snacks. She has very keen focus on gig-worker road safety and cleanliness.
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Qualitative Coding Matrix (based on the questions asked)

Objective	Interview Question	Codes	Sub-Theme	Theme
Objective 1: To explore the factors influencing consumers' decisions to use online	1. How do you typically decide what to order and from which app?	[P1]: Cross-app price checks (Swiggy vs. Zomato); hunting for discounts and coupons; cook absenteeism; work fatigue; managing split food cravings	Value-Driven App Comparison, & Family Preference Balancing	Price Sensitivity

food delivery services.		between kids (teenager wants Chinese, 9-year-old wants burgers). [P2]: Checking peer reviews; son's snack requests; vegetarian diet restriction.		
	2. Can you please explain in detail (this can let the interviewee explain in detail about their perspective	[P1]: Stacking cashback and promo coupons; free add-ons (like garlic bread); demand-based surge pricing sensitivity; delivery speed in high-traffic zones (Whitefield); kitchen location.	Deal Optimization, Speed, & Menu Fit	Platform Incentives
	3. What factors do you consider before deciding what and where to order?	[P2]: Frequently ordered restaurants; customer ratings; son's evening food choices.		
	4. Can you describe a situation in which something led you to order food online unexpectedly?	[P1]: Early morning school tiffin crunches (7 AM); sudden friend visits; weekend kid gatherings; spontaneous road trips; dinner mood swings.	Time Crunches, Social Gatherings, & Cooking Exhaustion	Situational Triggers
	5. What are the typical scenarios or occasions when you use food delivery (late nights, busy days, or gatherings)	[P2]: Late evening exhaustion after work; lack of energy to cook.		
Objective 2: To understand how online food delivery has influenced consumers' eating habits and daily lifestyles.	1. How has ordering food online changed your usual eating habits or routine?	[P1]: Diet shifts introduced by kids (shawarma, keto, fast food); children and friends bringing takeout to gatherings. [P2]: 24/7 food access leading to late-night snacking; home-cooked meals taking a	Dietary Shifts, & Reduced Dependence on Home Cooking	Habit Transformation

		back seat; instant convenience replacing home cooking.		
	2. Hypothetically, if all the food delivery apps were unavailable for a week, how would your daily meals change?	[P1]: Relying on quick staples (Maggi, curd rice); ordering from local cloud kitchens and neighborhood WhatsApp food groups. [P2]: Welcome financial savings; relief from son's constant ordering requests; managing with available groceries at home.	Domestic Adaptability vs. Informal Local Workarounds	Fallback Adaptation
	3. Do you think food delivery has affected how often you eat outside food? How?	[P1]: Ordering directly to outdoor spots (e.g., Cubbon Park) to avoid parking hassles; buying meals for train/airport travel; Saturday routine orders. [P2]: Heavy Road traffic and vehicle stress making dining out 'not worth it'; reserving dining out strictly for visiting guests; ordering in during exhaustion.	Avoiding Urban Traffic, & Parking Hassles	Mobility Convenience
	4. In what situations do you find yourself relying more on food delivery?			
Objective 3: To explore consumers' perceptions of trust and reliability in online food delivery services.	1. Have you ever stopped using a platform or switched to another? What led to that? - A time/scenario where the food arrived, and it did not meet your expectations	[P1]: Abandoning platforms when service declines (e.g., Uber Eats); switching to Amazon for better cashback; screening out inconsistent vendors using star ratings. [P2]: Trying different apps based on colleague and friend recommendations rather than sticking to one.	Service Quality Decline & Incentive-Driven	Platform Switching

	2. What makes you trust a food delivery platform (Swiggy, Zomato / ??) or restaurant?	[P1]: Friendly drivers who go the extra mile (bringing extra napkins/sauces); instant photo-verified app refunds; occasional frustration with unhelpful support agents.	Driver Hygiene, Swift Problem Resolution, & Road Safety Concerns	Trust Factors
	3. Can you describe an experience that increased or decreased your trust in a food delivery service? - Order tracking & Communication: Was customer service part of this experience? - How do you, as a customer, feel about the order tracking Interface & Related Customer Support? - What do you expect from a food delivery platform to consider it reliable?	[P2]: Delivery driver cleanliness, neat rain gear, and pleasant attitude; tracking app showing 'arrived' prematurely; deep concern over riders jumping traffic signals and speeding.		
	4. If you had to choose between Speed vs Accuracy (i.e. 10 min. faster delivery, vs order accuracy), what would you choose?	[P1]: Prefers speed when catching a flight or train; prioritizes accuracy and food quality during relaxed leisure times. [P2]: Strongly chooses quality, accurate food, and rider road safety over reckless 10-minute delivery promises.	Balancing Urgent Delivery with Food Quality & Rider Safety	Speed-Accuracy Tradeoff

Overall Institutional Theme

Human Vulnerability in Algorithm-Driven Food Ecosystems

Decision Factors

Lifestyle Changes

Trust and Ethics

Theories in context of discussion

When we further break down these grounded codes from the case study interview, there is further established Information System theories that justify the practices, been observed, e.g., the dilemma of bypassing traffic or parking bottlenecks or solving morning time crunches, connects very closely with the theory of task technology fit.

Objective	Domain /Cluster	Applicable Theory	Core Grounded Dimensions & Applications
To explore the factors influencing consumers' decisions to use online food delivery services.	Decision-Making, Friction & Lifestyles	Task-Technology Fit (TTF)	- Bypassing traffic & parking bottlenecks - Solving morning time crunches - Satisfying diverse food cravings
		Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB)	- Children cravings & Gen-Z pester power - Cooking fatigue & time poverty - Convenience-driven behavioral control
		Transaction Cost Economics (TCE)	- Multi-app price & discount arbitrage - Swiggy vs Zomato price comparison - Search & Information Costs
To understand how online food delivery has influenced consumers' eating habits and daily lifestyles.	Cross-Cutting Quality & Uncertainty	Signaling Theory	- Star ratings & peer customer reviews - Driver hygiene as quality proxy - Mitigating unobservable food preparation risks
To explore consumers' perceptions of trust and reliability in online food delivery services.	Trust, Reliability & Ethics	Theory of Swift Trust	- Driver as trust proxy at doorstep - Personal hygiene & clean rainwear - Hot food delivery & polite demeanor
		DeLone & McLean IS Success Model	- GPS real-time tracking fidelity - Automated photo-verified refunds - Driver extra-mile service recovery
		Expectation Confirmation Theory (ECT)	- Platform switching due to quality drops - Migration to Amazon for higher cashback - Continuous multi-homing behavior
		Norm Activation Model (NAM)	- Speed vs accuracy trade-off - Gig-worker traffic violations & road safety - Moral tension over reckless delivery timelines

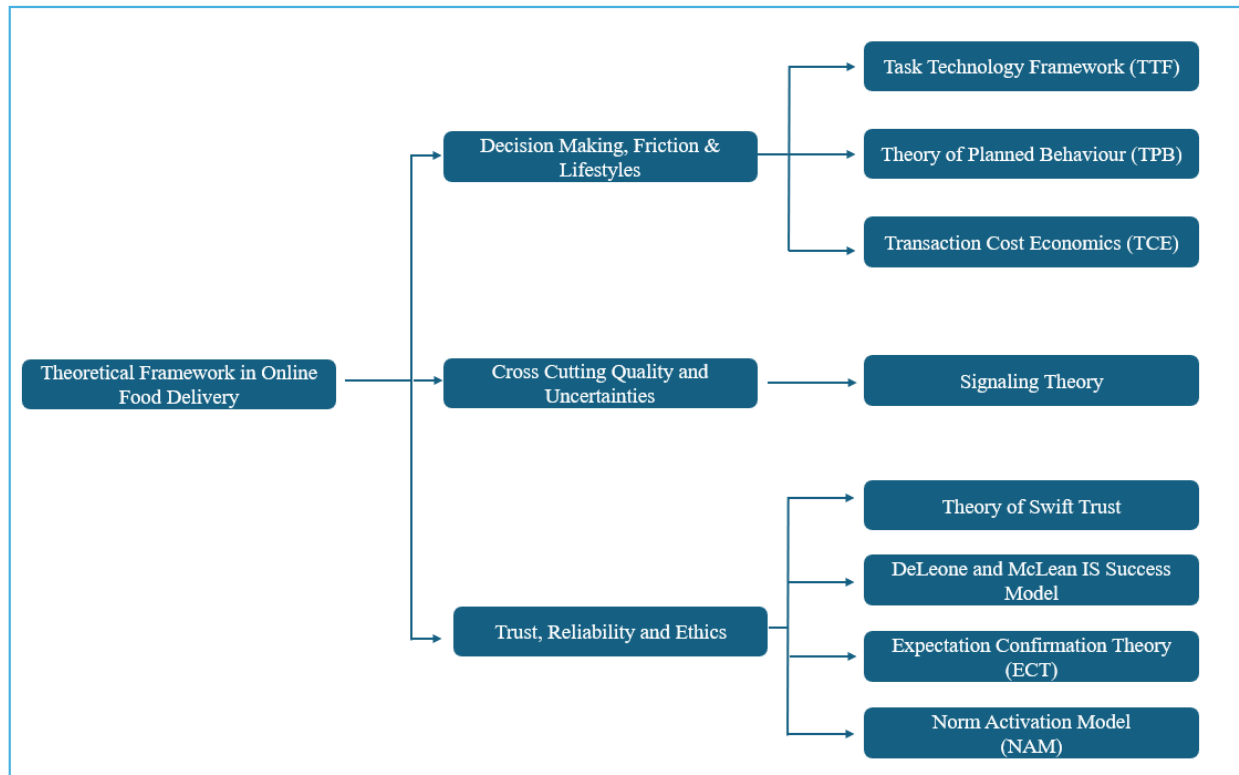


Fig: Theories in context of Thematic Analysis

Concluding Thoughts

Online food delivery in Indian cities is no longer just about convenience, it has become a daily coping mechanism for dealing with bad traffic, parking headaches, long work hours, and children demanding restaurant snacks at odd times. While apps try to win customers over with discounts, coupons, and algorithms, real customer trust is still won or lost right at the doorstep. People care deeply about whether the delivery driver is clean, polite, and handling the food with care, and many feel uneasy seeing riders risk their lives breaking traffic rules just to meet unrealistic delivery deadlines. At the same time, households constantly juggle budgets and healthy home-cooked meals against their kids' fast-food cravings, switching between apps the moment quality drops or prices jump. Ultimately, keeping customers loyal comes down to fair pricing, humane working conditions for delivery partners, and reliable, respectful service when things go wrong.